

Fig 15.1 Air Pollution

types of air pollutants

Air pollutants may exist in two major forms namely, gases and particulates.

15.3.1.1 Gaseous air pollutants

Oxides of sulphur, oxides of nitrogen, oxides of carbon, and hydrocarbons are the gaseous air pollutants.

a. Oxides of Sulphur

Sulphur dioxide and sulphur trioxide are produced by burning sulphur containing fossil fuels and roasting sulphide ores. Sulphur dioxide is a poisonous gas to both animals and plants. Sulphur dioxide causes eye irritation, coughing and respiratory diseases like asthma, bronchitis,etc.

Sulphur dioxide is oxidised into more harmful sulphur trioxide in the presence of particulate matter present in polluted air .

$$2SO_2 + O_2 \xrightarrow{\text{Particulate matter}} 2SO_3$$

SO_3 combines with atmospheric water vapour to form H_2SO_4 , which comes down in the form of acid rain.

$$SO_3 + H_2O \rightarrow H_2SO_4$$

Some harmful effects of acid rain will be discussed in section 15.3

b. Oxides of nitrogen

Oxides of nitrogen are produced during high temperature combustion processes, oxidation of nitrogen in air and from the combustion of fuels (coal, diesel, petrol etc.).

$$N_2 + O_2 \xrightarrow{>1210^oC} 2NO$$

$$2NO + O_2 \xrightarrow{1100^oC} 2NO_2$$

$$NO + O_3 \longrightarrow NO_2 + O_2$$

The oxides of nitrogen are converted into nitric acid which comes down in the form of acid rain. They also form reddish brown haze in heavy traffic. Nitrogen dioxide potentially damages plant leaves and retards photosynthesis. NO_2 is a respiratory irritant and it can cause asthma and lung injury. Nitrogen dioxide is also harmful to various textile fibres and metals.

c. Oxides of carbon

The major pollutants of oxides of carbon are carbon monoxide and carbon dioxide.

(i) Carbon Monoxide

Carbon monoxide is a poisonous gas produced as a result of incomplete combustion of coal or firewood. It is released into the air mainly by automobile exhaust. It binds with haemoglobin

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